

A COMPACT ANTHOLOGY OF MULTIETHNIC AMERICAN LITERATURE: STUDENT EDITION



Jennie Snow
Fitchburg State University

A Compact Anthology of Multiethnic
American Literature: Student Edition

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

This text was compiled on 06/07/2025

TABLE OF CONTENTS

[Acknowledgements](#)

[Licensing](#)

[Authors and Contributors](#)

[Licensing](#)

[1: FSU Land and Labor Acknowledgment](#)

[2: How to Use this Source and Licensing Information](#)

[3: Introduction- Self-Identity and Resistance](#)

[4: Jesús Colón \(1901-1974\)](#)

[5: Lorraine Hansberry \(1930-1965\)](#)

[6: Toni Morrison \(1931-2019\)](#)

[7: Maxine Hong Kingston \(1940-\)](#)

[8: Gloria Anzaldúa \(1942-2004\)](#)

[9: August Wilson \(1945-2005\)](#)

[10: Leslie Marmon Silko \(1948-\)](#)

[11: Afterword](#)

[Index](#)

[Glossary](#)

[Feedback](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

Acknowledgements

Acknowledgements

Thank you to Dr. Snow and FSU librarians, Connie Strittmatter and Renée Fratantonio, who took the initiative in creating the framework for this anthology and guiding us in the creation process. A thank you to all the student authors who contributed their work to the anthology and allowed their insights and perspectives to be shared. And finally a big thank you to all the authors being written about. Without them, we would not have our own knowledge and insight into multiethnic American literature, which is what we're sharing in writing this anthology. This anthology is dedicated to anyone who is reading it to further their knowledge and to those who wish to appreciate and understand the works of ethnic authors and the messages that they share.



Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Authors and Contributors

Introduction: Written by Shianne Harewood, Alice Lemieux, Danielle Varner, and Ketia Viel

I am Shianne Harewood a sophomore at Fitchburg State and majoring in early childhood education. I am studying education because I want to be the reason kids want to go to school and teach them information about history that may be hidden. I want to be able to make an impact on a kid's life and be remembered. Taking this class helped me with seeing different points of views and being able to relate and understand more in depth about different people's life experiences.

Alice Lemieux is a sophomore at Fitchburg State studying chemistry with a minor in art. She is working towards the forensic science field.

Danielle Varner is a junior at Fitchburg State studying sociology.

Ketia Viel is a Fitchburg State University student majoring in Human Services. I pursued this degree to make a difference in underprivileged areas. I like seeing lives transformed, and I hope to be known as a God-fearing woman who isn't afraid to be recognized in the future.

Jesus Colon: Written by Juan Pena-Deoleo

Juan Pena-Deoleo is a junior at Fitchburg State University. He is Dominican and was born and raised in Nashua, New Hampshire. He is studying Game Design.

Lorraine Hansberry: Written by Christopher Emslie

Chris Emslie is a student at Fitchburg State University.

Toni Morison: Written by Samuel Kontoes

Samuel Kontoes is a second-year student at Fitchburg State University, who studies Criminal Justice with the concentration of becoming a Police Officer. Kontoes is a white male from a Christian background.

Maxine Hong Kingston: Written by Nicki Lovenbury and Pedro Soares

Nicki Lovenbury is a second year, business administration student at Fitchburg State University.

The author, Pedro Soares, is a senior in Political Science at Fitchburg State University. As an international student coming from Brazil, Pedro started to develop his English writing skills and communications during his years at the university.

Gloria Anzaldúa: Written by Derek Schumaker

As the author for this chapter about Gloria Anzaldúa, I would like to formally introduce myself. My name is Derek Schumaker, and I am a 22-year-old male from the Boston, Massachusetts area. I grew up in a tight knit family and played sports growing up. I currently attend Fitchburg State University and study Criminal Justice in hopes of one day becoming a police officer.

August Wilson: Written by Rebecca Joseph

Rebecca Joseph is completing her senior year at Fitchburg State University. She is studying Communications Media. Her Theater concentration major heavily influences her vision in all aspects analyzing media and literature.

Leslie Marmon Silko: Written by Kayla Forbes and Jorjia Tsilibocos

Kayla Forbes is a sophomore at Fitchburg State University. She is in the criminal justice 4+1 program to become a police officer in the future. She is from Marshfield Massachusetts.

Jorjia Tsilibocos is a junior at Fitchburg State University. She is from Ludlow, Massachusetts. She is also a Psychology major hoping to become a school psychologist.

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

1: FSU Land and Labor Acknowledgment

The Fitchburg State University Community recognizes historical injustices. We acknowledge the legacy of the ancestral homelands and traditional territories of Indigenous Peoples from which they were dispossessed. We are cognizant that we cannot separate the history of our university or our community from the history of colonialism and slavery in the United States.

We recognize and honor the members of the Algonquian Peoples: Nipmuc, Pennacook, and Wabanaki Confederacy, whose ancestral land we now call the Fitchburg State University campus. We also acknowledge the removal of these peoples from this area and the systemic erasure of their complex and unique history.

We acknowledge the heritage of the African and Caribbean diaspora. We acknowledge the reality of slavery and forced labor that built this area.

The legacy of colonialism and slavery persists today as we continue to work towards racial justice, equity, inclusion, liberation, and community, and strive to dismantle the oppressive social systems interwoven into the fabric of our national and regional heritage.

Source: "Fitchburg State Land and Labor Acknowledgement," *The Amelia V. Galluci-Cirio Library*, <https://fitchburgstate.libguides.com...nited%20States>.

1: FSU Land and Labor Acknowledgment is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

2: How to Use this Source and Licensing Information

This open educational resource was created by the students of Jennie Snow's Multiethnic American Literature class at Fitchburg State University. This resource can be used in both a historical and literary perspective for creative work. The anthology consist of both background history and well as personal history on the authors and their lives along with how that may affect their work. This source can also be used to view in depth analysis of the authors work and how the themes and ideas persist across different individuals, groups and times.

Licensing Information

This book is open access licensed under [CC BY-SA 4.0](#), except where otherwise noted.

Some chapters carry their own open license assigned by its author and should be consulted to understand the terms of reuse.

[2: How to Use this Source and Licensing Information](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3: Introduction- Self-Identity and Resistance

Introduction: Self-Identity & Resistance

Danielle Varner, Ketia Viel, Alice Lemieux, and Shianne Harewood

This anthology was written by Dr. Snow's "Ethnic American Literature" class at Fitchburg State for the Fall 2022 semester. As written in already existing anthologies, the purpose of anthologies such as the one we've written is to educate and expose the readers to new ideas and understandings. In the case of this anthology, we are giving voice to multiple ethnic American authors, as opposed to some already existing anthologies which are dominated by white authors. As written in the introduction of an anthology of black literature, *Black American Writers Past and Present*, this anthology "Comes as a partial cure for a 400-year wave of literary amnesia" (Rush xiii). It's impossible to remember everything that has ever been written and it is just as hard to remember everything that has ever happened to an individual or group of people. In addition to this, there may be things that have never been written about perhaps because it was too hard to write about or the author didn't know how to go about it. It can be hard to write about difficult topics. Still, by writing about these difficult topics and having these conversations, knowledge can be shared among a large group of people. This is the purpose of our class anthology. By writing about our chosen themes of self-identity and resistance, there will be knowledge shared among the student authors and anyone else who views the anthology. The hope is that the discussion of these multiethnic American authors and stories will spark important conversations.

The overall concept of multiethnic American literature is just reliving history from a narrative perspective. Through the authors in this collection, you can get a sense of persecution, loneliness, and the notion of wanting to be seen and heard. There is a sense of self-identity and resistance that is represented through these pieces of writing. We have gathered different pieces of writing to see different perspectives of different backgrounds. This anthology is written by students that have been impacted by powerful writers that they feel should get some extra light shined on.

What is Ethnic American Literature?

The background of ethnic American literature comes from the curiosity of people not hearing people of color's voices and representation in the classroom growing up in middle and high school. This course gives people the chance to understand other people's way of thinking and put themselves in other people's shoes regarding what they went through in their life. It is easy to talk about all the good things that have happened in this world but it is a tough conversation to have when we talk about things like slavery, and this is where the course ethnic American literature comes in handy. This anthology opens up people's minds but it also gives a safe place for people to express how they truly feel about a piece of writing and how they can relate to it or not.

In school you often learn about activists and how they forced a change to happen. For example, Martin Luther King Junior is known by many people. He is taught in schools starting at a young age because he made history on many occasions changing the political view of African Americans and Americans with other ethnic backgrounds. Even though most people learn about him in history class there are many pieces of his history left out. This anthology helps us dig deeper and get to know more about him and people who made similar impacts on the world.

Looking at literature in addition to history brings to light other aspects of people's lives that may not have been looked at otherwise. People should be motivated to understand more than what is presented to them in a history textbook. The pieces of literature that are presented in this anthology bring this motivation in students forward. The pieces of writing that will be looked at throughout this whole anthology give you insight into people's upbringing from 1865-1965.

During this time there was a lot of history between slavery, rights, the civil war, the declaration of independence, the assassination of many important people in the country, riots, and invasions. Being able to go back and look at what has happened and look at other people's points of view help students, and people understand more in-depth. For example, another person in history that should be looked at in literature and not just history is Malcolm X's autobiography which came out in October 1965. Malcolm was an American Muslim minister and a human rights activist during the civil rights movement. What we learn about in history class is that he was a vocal advocate for black empowerment. But if we look at his life from a literary point of view we will get to know the man that is behind the name Malcolm X. Being able to look at his life as a literary point we get feelings we get the truth, the hustle, the low hard part in life and the powerful high parts. Starting low and in a hard place you can either accept and stay in there or you can rise and make something of yourself and this autobiography shows just that.

Self-identity and Resistance

This collection of multiethnic American authors allow us to see the world through different perspectives from anywhere in the world at any given time. These writers all have new and unique experiences of their lives, their travels, the changes and the struggles. History is best recorded when different perspectives are included. Without the introduction of different people, how can a full story be perceived? How can the truth be revealed and a sense of unity form among the view of people? If these perspectives are hidden in the shadows then only a single part of history remains intact while the rest of history gets tossed away soon to be forgotten. Literature plays this role of historian extremely well, it reaches into what a person truly feels and allows them to express their feelings and not to mention how long literature prevails throughout history in comparison to film, photography and other forms. One of the only forms of expression that stretches as long is art but with that comes a sense of obscurity and one cannot discount that the art might mean one thing over another. America is described as a melting pot of cultures, yet when things melt they mix together and this is not how history is truly seen. American history is mostly devoted to the white settlers who came across the Atlantic Ocean. Every now and then a sprinkle of a culture is thrown in but it seems as though these perspectives are brought in when they are relevant to the stories already being portrayed. The lack of known history of those with a different background, experiences, and vices ruins history as those who are pushed down and have their lives hidden, they may call America home but they do not feel as though the history of this home is also built upon their backs and what they brought to the future.

If the literature of multiethnic Americans is shown to the world then a more structured interpretation can be obtained of true history. In this anthology we work to bring a higher awareness to these stories. We work to include many perspectives from around the world, with different stories, and in different parts of the country. The scope of multiethnic American literature is too extensive to include solely in one anthology so we set a timeframe of 1860s-1960s. This time brings events that caused tragedies such as the end of the Civil War, the Trail of Tears, Asian internment camps, and the Civil Rights movement. Despite all the tragedies going on this time was also a moment when the presence of these people rapidly grew which acts a secondary reasoning for the timeframe of the anthology.

The authors chosen for the anthology all show themes of self identity and resistance in their work. People such as Jesús Colón use self identity to show that groups of people are their own and have beliefs, goals, and purposes unique to themselves and that these are pushed down by others with more power and influence and those with different thoughts get shoved aside or are barely even seen in the overall United States. However some authors such as Toni Morrison show self identity in a way that is more so that every person is an individual and will clash with others in large or small situations. Morrison more focuses on how self identity will change, adapt, and can be manipulated by those who influence that person. A final perspective would be that of Hong Kingston focusing more on a struggle between oneself on what their own self identity is which persists among many authors living in countries other than where they were born. Many authors also focus on the theme of resistance. Jesús Colón and James Baldwin tackle this in different ways, while Colón focuses more on the physical retaliation aspect of fighting back as resistance to outer forces, Baldwin pushes this more to peace saying that one should only spread love not hate. Some also stray from this duality, such as Lorraine Hansberry using joy as a form of resistance as if to push someone off your shoulder rather than allow them to drag you down. All of the authors featured in our *Compact Anthology* use unique perspectives and all of their past experiences to craft and formulate a story to not only pull readers in but to get across a message.

A Compact Anthology For and By Students

Throughout this course, we have focused on Hispanic, Native American, black, and women writers. This anthology is going to go into specific detail about how different authors with different backgrounds are connected with a few themes, and how those voices have been silenced for too long. The author that will be looked at are Hong Kingston, Silko, Toni Morrison, Lorraine Hansberry, Wilson, Baldwin, Colón and Anzaldúa. Focusing on the audience that needs to be reached whether that is high schoolers, professors, parents, or people in general. They all recognize that being themselves either breaks or elevates them up, which is why we use the term "self identity." The authors you will read about are from the oppressed group, the group that was not seen or heard, and their pieces demonstrate the theme of suffering and resistance because of the time period in which they were raised or wrote them. The chapters are separated by author and organized according to their date of birth. We made this decision in order to show the progression of events happening in the world at the time of their writing and how it impacted different groups.

James Baldwin is an exceptional African American writer. Baldwin lived from 1924 to 1987 and was raised in Harlem, New York. Baldwin writes in a highly precise and succinct manner. In pieces like "Fire Next Time," he shows his background, the obstacles of being black, and how he had to embrace his self-identity. Reading Baldwin's writings can give you a feel of the racial divide between black and white people during the time he was writing his pieces, as well as an idea of what a resolution for white and black people would look like.

Anzaldúa is a unique novelist who is regarded an ethnic American writer. Gloria Evangelina Anzaldúa is well-known for her expertise in queer theory and feminist theory. Anzaldúa was born on September 26, 1942, in Texas, and died on May 15, 2004 in California. Her work is well-known for bringing the LGBTQ concept to Latino society. Although many civilizations did not, Anzaldúa provided possibilities for many lesbians and queers to publicly disclose their self-identity.

One of the voices in American ethnic writing is the Puerto Rican author Jesus Colon. On January 20, 1901, Colon was born; he died on May 14, 1974. Through Colons' articles, he discusses his experiences as a Puerto Rican living in New York. Through his works, you can also see how his sense of self in Puerto Rico and America are very different from one another. In Puerto Rico, it wasn't necessary to convince people that you were deserving of their company, whereas in America, he had to fight against negative emotions and missed out on opportunities because of his skin color.

Jesús Colón, a Puerto Rican novelist, is one of the voices in American ethnic writing. Colón was born on January 20, 1901, and died on May 14, 1974. Colón's essays explore his experiences as a Puerto Rican residing in New York. His paintings also demonstrate how his concept of self in Puerto Rico and America differ significantly. In Puerto Rico, you didn't have to persuade people that you were worthy of their business, however in America, he had to combat negative feelings and missed out on possibilities because of his complexion.

Asian-American author Maxine Hong Kingston writes novels. Kingston was born in California in 1940, and she is still alive. Her stories all convey the idea of understanding one's purpose and being able to accomplish what one wants rather than deciding one's own choices. Her stories also highlight being a voice for the voiceless women.

Leslie Marmon Silko is a Native American ethnic writer from the Laguna Pueblo tribe. She was born on March 5, 1948, in New Mexico, and has Anglo American, Mexican, and Laguna Pueblo ancestry. She is well-known for her short stories and poetry, which demonstrate her innovative and astute literary abilities. Silko's works do, in subtle ways, convey what it's like to be a Native American; it's more about her portraying Native American culture than it is about expressing the oppression they face because of their heritage. Silko's stories reflect her idea of a powerful woman, as well as the importance of cultural self-identity.

Toni Morrison is an African-American writer who was born on February 18, 1931 and died on August 5, 2019. According to the National Women's History Museum, Morrison is "the first African-American woman to win the Nobel Prize in Literature, Morrison's work has inspired a generation of writers to follow in her footsteps." Morrison's writing approach is primarily focused on the cultural influences of African American communities. Her word choice is also vivid and direct, but this is done to highlight her readers the reality of being African American.

Lorraine Hansberry is a writer of African American descent who lived from May 19, 1930 to January 12, 1965. According to the National Women's Hall of Fame, "Lorraine Hansberry authored *A Raisin in the Sun*, becoming the first Black woman to have a Broadway show produced, the first Black playwright and youngest American to receive the New York Drama Critics' Circle Award for Best American Play (1959), and the first Black American to win the Drama Desk Award." Hansberry's writings and exhibits are straightforward in conveying her ideas, and she values sociocultural craft.

August Wilson, also known as Fredrick August Kittle, was born in Pennsylvania on April 27, 1945 and died on October 2, 2005. He is most recognized for his groundbreaking cycle of ten plays chronicling the African-American experience in the twentieth century. Wilson's plays are realistic and utilize African American dialect. His plays also include almost entirely black characters.

Works Cited

Alexander, Kerri Lee. "Toni Morrison." *The National Women's History Museum*, 2019. <https://www.womenshistory.org/education-resources/biographies/toni-morrison>. Accessed 11 Dec. 2022

"11 Things You Should Know About August Wilson - the Greene Space." *11 Things You Should Know About August Wilson - the Greene Space*, 2022.

"Hansberry, Lorraine - National Women's Hall of Fame." *The National Women's Hall of Fame*, www.womenofthehall.org/inductee/lorraine-hansberry. Accessed 11 Dec. 2022.

Rush, Theresa Gunnels, et al. *Black American Writers Past and Present: A Biographical and Bibliographical Dictionary*. 1975.

3: Introduction- Self-Identity and Resistance is shared under a [CC BY-SA](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

4: Jesús Colón (1901-1974)

Jesús Colón

Justin Puppo

Essay

Jesús Colón is a Puerto Rican who has written many pieces about the working class perspective on culture and America. Culture is the biggest part of his writings. He is known for writing about the average working class man and making people see the world through the eyes of the blue-collar workers. Jesús Colón is mainly known for writing “A Puerto Rican in New York and Other Sketches” and “The Two United States”. I will be mainly focusing on “A Puerto Rican in New York and Other Sketches” since I like a few of the sketches within his writings in this piece. There are two specific skits that I will be focusing on in his writings, “The Day My Father Got Lost” and “A Hero in the Junk Truck”.

First, I will start with “The Day My Father Got Lost” since it comes first in his sketches. I like this sketch because it shows how after moving to America from Puerto Rico, there weren’t many jobs for them and through determination they ended up getting some. It was a routine day, where everyday the same thing repeated. After getting used to the schedule one thing changed and caused chaos in the family. The father was not able to speak English and he got used to landmarks based on looks. When displays in stores changed, the dad was not able to recognize where he was, which made him lose his kids in the city of Harlem. After the kids try and look for him for a bit they eventually give up and go home, which for them is a long journey to travel without an adult. When they eventually get home, the dad shows up not too much later and all’s well that ends well. The struggle of the whole family moving to America and having to work immediately is very stressful and because they are also in an unknown environment, it makes it a lot more challenging to support themselves. This was also during World War I, so there was a lot of struggle in the country as well.

Next is “A Hero in the Junk Truck”. As Jesus and his wife were riding the bus home, they saw a junk truck full of debris from a building being torn down. There was a picture above the drivers cabin of the truck with a man named “Bolivar”. To Jesus and his wife he is seen as the “George Washington to a score of Latin American countries” and because of this him and his wife get off at the next stop and go over to the truck. They talk to the person who seems to not care about who it is and he finally asks if they want the picture. They of course say yes because of the cultural significance of the man. While in this conversation a crowd formed asking who the person was (more out of curiosity than actual interest) and after this dispersed because they got their answer. Since they weren’t allowed to bring this big painting back on the bus they went to one of their friends’ places so that they could drive them back. When his friend opened the door he just said “Bolivar” and Jesus and his wife were ecstatic. As we can see here, the history of his Puerto Rican culture is very important to him. This says a lot about how informed people in America are about other cultures because of how they didn’t know of such an important man. To compare someone like this to George Washington and then not have anyone know who it is must have been a heartbreaking experience.

To conclude, Jesús Colón is a Puerto Rican writer who focuses on the working class perspective in America and how it connects to his culture. His culture is very important to him and because of that he tries to spread information about his culture and why it means so much to him.



"Sanitation Workers and Garbage Truck," by Seattle Municipal Archives is licensed under [CC BY 2.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/)

Excerpt

When talking about the framed painting of Bolivar, Colon says “Nobody knew. Nobody seemed to care really. The question was asked more out of curiosity than real interest.”

Work Cited

Holton, A. (2013). “Little Things Are Big”: Race and the Politics of Print Community in the Writings of Jesús Colón. *MELUS: The Journal of the Society for the Study of the Multi-Ethnic Literature of the United States*, 38(2), 5–18.

"Jesús Colón." Gale Literature: Contemporary Authors, Gale, 2000. Gale Literature Resource Center, link.gale.com/apps/doc/H1000019778/LitRC?u=mclin_c_fitchcol&sid=bookmark-LitRC&xid=232616da. Accessed 7 Nov. 2022.“

Stavans, Ilan and Edna Acosta-Belén. *The Norton Anthology of Latino Literature*. W.W. Norton & Co, 2011.

4: [Jesús Colón \(1901-1974\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

5: Lorraine Hansberry (1930-1965)

A Raisin in the Sun

Christopher Emslie

A Raisin in the Sun tells the story of a black family living in the 1950s era of American history. It showcases the struggles a black family would have to go through at the time. It showcases a version of ethnic American Literature. Lorraine Hansberry wrote this play, the most famous play she has ever written. Lorraine Hansberry was an African American writer who was very well known during her career. She has contributed so much to ethnic American literature and literature as a whole with the themes and messages she works with in her plays. I have chosen her as my author for this literature anthology because I found her work very intriguing and important. Her play *A Raisin in the Sun* has helped me understand the African American experience and struggles better than any history book ever has. She is a very talented writer, and she has many amazing pieces of work to show for it.

Lorraine Hansberry, born May 19, 1930, lived a middle class lifestyle as a kid growing up in Chicago, Illinois. Just because she may have been a little more fortunate than others, does not mean she did not do her part to spread awareness of the mistreatment of African Americans at the time. Growing up her family helped with different activist groups to help make a change in America. She took up interest in writing and moved to New York to help kickstart her playwright career. Her first Broadway show was none other than *A Raisin in the Sun*. The play was an immediate success as it played on Broadway for 530 performances starting on March 11, 1959. One of the biggest reasons for its success was its accurate ability to showcase the 1950s for traditional African American families. She showed off themes of hope, and those feelings of hope being shattered by the realities of the situation for the Younger family. She presented how the Youngers dealt with racism on a daily basis and how it was constantly straining to their daily lives. How it seemed almost impossible to advance up in the world just because of who they were. There were many conflicts in *A Raisin in the Sun*, but they all stemmed from the main conflict of racism.

A Raisin in the Sun focuses on a family in Chicago named the Youngers. Walter Younger is the father of the house and he is married to Ruth. The family has been struggling in poor living conditions and are blessed when Walters mother Lena Younger gets a 10000 dollar check from her dead husband's life insurance. This introduces the main conflict of the play as all of the members in the family have different ideas on what they want to do with it. Walter wants to invest the money into a liquor business, his sister Beneatha wants to spend the money on her college education, and Mama Younger wants to use the money to buy a house in a bad neighborhood so they can live in better conditions. Lorraine Hansberry uses each character's personality traits to show the struggle of African Americans during the time. She shows that all the members in the family have the same goal, to provide a better life for their families. However, they all believe in a different way to do it. They have all struggled with these living conditions their whole lives, and they believe the money is their way out. All of them seem so afraid of messing it up, that they are hesitant to agree on what they should do with it. Hansberry does a great job showing how discrimination during this time causes conflict inside of a black families household because they all know how hard it is to make it in America when you are a person of color, so they want to make sure their way out (\$10000) is used in the most effective way.

A critical review by *New York Times* writer Brooks Atkinson in 1959 agreed with this, as they commended Lorraine Hansberry's ability to show the problems of society at the time through the Younger family's arguments about how to use the money. "The son is dreaming of success in a business deal. And the daughter, who is race-conscious, wants to become a physician and heal the wounds of her people. After a long delay the widow receives \$10,000 as the premium on her husband's life insurance... For *A Raisin in the Sun* is a play about human beings who want, on the one hand, to preserve their family pride and, on the other hand, to break out of the poverty that seems to be their fate. Not having any axe to grind, Miss Hansberry has a wide range of topics to write about-some of them hilarious, some of them painful in the extreme." Atkinson mentions how poverty seems to be the Younger's fate, and that the only chance out of this fate is with this money. For a family that has lived with nothing, Hansberry shows their desperate nature as they struggle to figure out what the best move for the family is. This desperate nature was the accurate reality of many African American families. This desperate nature comes back to haunt them later on in the story. Lorraine Hansberry uses Walter Younger as the "tragic hero" character of the story. A tragic hero is the protagonist whose major flaw ends up resulting in his/her downfall. Walter's tragic flaw was that he had a dream that he believed could get his family rich and out of poverty. That dream was the liquor store investment hitting big. However, he was so clouded by that dream that he did not see the reality of his situation. An investment like that was very risky and it was much safer to buy a house and get out of their bad living conditions. Walter's tragic flaw consumed him so much that he ended up investing the money into the liquor store without telling his family. That proves to be very costly as the man in charge of the money, Willy Harris, runs off with the money leaving Walter and his

family nothing. With this tragic fall of Walters' character, Hansberry once again shows the harsh reality of life as an African American family in the 1950s, hoping to make a better life for yourselves yet again struck down by society.

In spite of all of the negatives of this play, Lorraine Hansberry offers hope towards racism in America in the way she ends the story for the Youngers. Mama still goes through with buying the house even though they do not have the 10000 anymore. It will be harder on the Younger family but they still find a way to make it work. In spite of this racism rears its ugly head as a white man named Mr. Karl Lindner offers them money if they do not go through with purchasing the house. He lives in the area and speaks for the whole neighborhood when he says that they do not want a black family living there. Walter wants to accept the money from Mr. Lindner, and we are led to believe that he will because throughout the play Hansberry has shown us that racism always seems to keep the Youngers in the same spot. However, we finally see a change in Walter. He finally decides that his family is more important than some money. He stops giving up in the face of racism and decides to go through with the house purchase. After all the conflict and fighting the Younger family has done throughout the play, they are finally together in this decision. They know it will be hard dealing with racism in the neighborhood and their lack of money, but they will pursue it together because that is what will get them through. Lorraine Hansberry delivers the final theme of the story, that to fight racism we need to be united together as a group.

Lorraine Hansberry is the perfect author to use for our anthology. Her play *A Raisin in the Sun* described racism of ethnic groups in America in the perfect way. She showed what a black family had to grow through. She showed how racism is always prevalent and how society pushes many ethnic groups to poverty, a poverty that is very hard to get out of. She is one of the many prominent authors of ethnic American literature, and her play *A Raisin in the Sun* was important in getting people to understand racism's effect in our society. Out of all pieces of ethnic American literature I have read, I understood this play the most. It painted American racism in a way that was so easy to understand. It showed me how bad it truly has been. But not only that, she also showed that there was a way to break out of the chains of racism. When presented with this anthology, I knew I had to use Lorraine Hansberry.

Work Cited

Hansberry, Lorraine. *A Raisin in the Sun: A Drama in Three Acts*. Hassell Street Press, 2021.

Stephens, Thomas M. *Dictionary of Latin American Racial and Ethnic Terminology*. University Press of Florida, 1999.

5: [Lorraine Hansberry \(1930-1965\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

6: Toni Morrison (1931-2019)

Toni Morrison

Samuel Kontoes

Toni Morrison is a unique poet when it comes to her literature on African American culture and its evolution. Her stories take place in the time period of American history, where racism was widespread. Morrison writes from the perspective of African Americans and focalizes heavily on the self-identity of her characters. The stories emphasize the struggles that minorities faced and their reactions of resistance towards this human brutality. Morrison's accurate and interesting depiction of these perspectives have earned her the prestigious award of The Nobel Peace Prize in 1993. In Morrison's acceptance speech, she explains the importance of language. As everybody must die one day; we must remember that language will be edged into history forever (Morrison 1993). Morrison was the first ever African American female to win this award, which reiterates her ability as a poet. Morrison has developed interesting characters that contribute to the success of her story's purpose. These novels have a common theme, which is the betrayal of whites against blacks. This theme reflects on the characters that Morrison introduces and guides the direction of her novels. In retrospect, Morrison showed the methods of how African Americans responded to this inhumane behavior and also their assimilation into American society.

Toni Morrison's style of literature is very interesting based on her ability to engage the reader. Her characterization in these novels are descriptive, but the mystery of these characters are unveiled throughout the entirety of her writings. She has separated herself from the typical poet and has influenced the public's view on American history. In Morrison's Nobel Peace Prize speech, she emphasizes the importance of language in human nature. In Morrison's acceptance speech she states that "Oppressive language does more than represent violence; it is violence; does more than represent the limits of knowledge; it limits knowledge" (Morrison 1993). Violence can be physical or verbal and it has the ability to scar individuals. The hatred and violence against newly introduced cultures limits the capability of human evolution. Morrison's speech delivers a message that exposes the dominant role that whites desired and held. It simply "block[s] access to cognition for both the excluder and the excluded" (Morrison, 1993). Oppressive behavior is a waste of time for the development of humans when we fail to mutually work together. Morrison's writings that revolved around blacks have exposed the realities of their experiences in early America. She has brought attention and light to ethnic groups that have been unappreciated and unrepresented in literature.

"We die. That may be the meaning of life. But we do language. That may be the measure of our lives" (Morrison 1993).

Morrison's characters are interesting and commonly have a past that is faced with hardship. The experiences she shares through her stories are a classic representation of slavery in early America. These harsh realities have heavily impacted these characters. Morrison's stories have a common theme of self-identity in her novels. African Americans were forced to discover their own identity in society, which was difficult because of racist whites. This also made it hard for Africans to develop as a community due to their low population. Morrison directly challenges the opposing evils, who are blinded by power and control. Chia-yen Ku states that "Morrison's books challenge these expected standards and address 'inappropriate' issues" (617). Morrison does not shy away from controversial topics and will challenge past societal norms. She has proudly represented the African American community thus exposing the setbacks blacks were faced with. Morrison's novels have set a standard for every new generation of readers.

The betrayal of whites against blacks in ethnic literature has highlighted important social conflicts. The other common theme of resistance displayed in Morrison's writings is the reason for racial equality. African Americans took the stand against cultural assimilation and developed their own self-identity. Morrison displays this in *Beloved*, where the main characters escaped from the brutal torture of their slave plantation. For example, Morrison's character "Denver," is faced with social isolation, but dynamic in nature throughout the story. Her experiences have forced her to move closer to her community and depend more on loving relationships. Morrison's novels teaches its readers that you must always challenge evil and be your own self. This is achieved through her characters, who are motivated to be free from their community's expectations and black identity (DLB 33). Lawrie Balfour stated, "freedom, for Morrison, is enacted through language, through the imagination of lives unrecorded by official history" (671). Thus, relating back to Morrison's Peace Prize speech, where she emphasizes the power of language. Our freedom is taken through the words of others and how they seek to control vulnerable groups. Morrison's focus on resistance has promoted the lesson of standing up for your own true self-identity.

The history of racism in America's past is haunting and through the stories written by Morrison we get a better understanding. This understanding is an awful reality of human nature from our ancestors. Morrison is consistent in her literature and thorough in her details. Her poetic style keeps the reader engaged and interested in the development of each character's self-identity. Morrison does not shy away from sharing the extremities of racism. Morrison's ability has earned her prestige as a poet and has influenced the perception of her audience. She encourages individuals to resist against wrong and to fight for love. New generations are left with the language of Toni Morrison, who will always be remembered for her attribution to ethnic literature.

Excerpt

"She is convinced that when language dies, out of carelessness, disuse, indifference and absence of esteem, or killed by fiat, not only she herself, but all users and makers are accountable for its demise. In her country children have bitten their tongues off and use bullets instead to iterate the voice of speechlessness, of disabled and disabling language, of language adults have abandoned altogether as a device for grappling with meaning, providing guidance, or expressing love. But she knows tongue-suicide is not only the choice of children. It is common among the infantile heads of state and power merchants whose evacuated language leaves them with no access to what is left of their human instincts for they speak only to those who obey, or in order to force obedience.

The systematic looting of language can be recognized by the tendency of its users to forgo its nuanced, complex, mid-wifely properties for menace and subjugation. Oppressive language does more than represent violence; it is violence; does more than represent the limits of knowledge; it limits knowledge. Whether it is obscuring state language or the faux-language of mindless media; whether it is the proud but calcified language of the academy or the commodity driven language of science; whether it is the malign language of law-without-ethics, or language designed for the estrangement of minorities, hiding its racist plunder in its literary cheek – it must be rejected, altered and exposed. It is the language that drinks blood, laps vulnerabilities, tucks its fascist boots under crinolines of respectability and patriotism as it moves relentlessly toward the bottom line and the bottomed-out mind. Sexist language, racist language, theistic language – all are typical of the policing languages of mastery, and cannot, do not permit new knowledge or encourage the mutual exchange of ideas" (Morrison 1993).



"Toni Morrison Lecture" by Mike Strasser/USMA PAO is licensed under [CC BY-NC-ND 2.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/2.0/).

Works Cited

Balfour, Lawrie. "'To Manipulate American English': Toni Morrison's Word-Work as a Practice of Freedom." *American Quarterly*, vol. 73, no. 3, 2021, pp. 671–691., doi:10.1353/aq.2021.0040.

Blake, Susan. "Toni Morrison." *Dictionary of Literary Biography (Afro-American Fiction Writers after 1955)*, Vol 33. Ed. Thadious M. Davis and Trudier Harris. Detroit: Gale Research Co, 1984.187–99.

Ku, Chia-yen. "Not Safe for the Nursery? Toni Morrison's Storybooks for Children." *EurAmerica*, vol. 36, no. 4, Dec. 2006, pp. 613–49.

Morrison, Toni. *Beloved*. Vintage Classics, 2007.

“The Nobel Prize in Literature 1993.” *NobelPrize.org*, www.nobelprize.org/prizes/literature/1993/morrison/lecture/.

6: Toni Morrison (1931-2019) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

7: Maxine Hong Kingston (1940-)

Essay 1

Kingston's Anthology

Pedro Soares

Born in 1940, Maxine Hong Kingston is identified as the most influential Asian American author of the twentieth century. Throughout her work, especially with “The Woman Warrior” and “China Men”, Kingston demonstrated her legacy to the world by writing about important topics that were not very commonly addressed at the time. As a first-generation Chinese American, Kingston brings personal experience to her writings about gender, race, exclusion, class, and identity. Through fiction, Maxine Hong-Kingston brings similarities from her life, detailing her culture and experiences into stories that represented millions of people and that built her reputation.

By being a first-generation Chinese American, Maxine Hong-Kingston had a different perspective of concepts, experiences, and tradition. In an old, traditional and feudal China, ethics and moral concepts were very distinguished from the pattern that we live in Western civilization, “When Chinese girls listened to the adults talk-story, we learned that we failed if we grew up to be wives or slaves.” (Kingston 4) In her book, “The Woman Warrior”, Kingston addresses some problems involving women's life in Chinese society at the time. By relating into the folklore of *Fa Mu Lan*, a Chinese warrior that had to pretend to be a man in order to defend her family, Kingston writes about circumstances where women would go through some traumas provoked by the traditional suppression of a patriarchal society, such as “It is more profitable to raise geese than daughters.” (Kingston 43) As many other girls, Kingston grew into this society, repressing their dreams and expectations for life, leading to disappointment.

“When Chinese girls listened to the adults talk-story, we learned that we failed if we grew up to be but wives or slaves. We could be heroines, swordswomen.” (Kingston 1)

As a female protagonist, a warrior and defender of her family, Maxine Hong-Kingston exemplifies the difficulties faced by the woman that faces poverty, war and mostly, cultural restrictions. Following the legend of *Fa Mu Lan*, Kingston reconstructs the image of a woman within Chinese society, where she brings sensitivity, subjectivity, but overall, strength to the girls that are growing in this pattern, trying to avoid more trauma. According to the Washington Post Book World reviewer William McPherson, *The Woman Warrior* expresses a terrifying and very literal story of growing up in a vivid and mysterious mix of cultures. Throughout the story, it is evident that Kingston wants to manifest female sensitivity into a traditional Chinese woman and live with a combination of continuity of the Chinese culture and integration of moral concepts to the woman (Kingston 45).

By presenting her autobiography and using history, Kingston explores gender roles in a Chinese-American identity. According to LeiLani Nishime in her analysis of *The Woman Warrior*, Maxine Hong-Kingston raises questions through mythology about the conception of gender and genre and the notion of public and private in relation to these concepts, especially to the Chinese-American identity.

The main insight behind Maxine Hong-Kingston work is to present to the world the differences, and mainly, the difficulties that other cultures and lifestyles can have in people's lives. The challenge behind some groups within the society in order to achieve some success, and even get their own rights enforced, shows that there is an important and substantial need for change in our daily lives. And with given opportunities, Kingston shows to all cultures and societies that, “Girls are necessary too” (Kingston 25). By understanding the function within the society of every person and group, without repression and favoritism, it is possible to live in a place with glory and success.

Excerpt

“After I grew up, I heard the chant of Fa Mu Lan, the girl who took her father's place in battle. Instantly I remembered that as a child I had followed my mother about the house, the two of us singing about how Fa Mu Lan fought gloriously and returned alive from war to settle in the village. I had forgotten this chant that was once mine, given me by my mother, who may not have known its power to remind. She said I would grow up a wife and a slave, but she taught me the song of the warrior woman, Fa Mu Lan. I would have to grow up a warrior woman.” (Kingston 4)

Menstrual days did not interrupt my training; I was as strong as on any other day. “You're now an adult,” explained the old woman on the first one, which happened halfway through my stay on the mountain. “You can have children.” I had thought I had cut myself

when jumping over my swords, one made of steel and the other carved out of a single block of jade. “However,” she added, “we are asking you to put off children for a few more years.” (Kingston 11)

“I hid from battle only once, when I gave birth to our baby. In dark and silver dreams I had seen him falling from the sky, each night closer to the earth, his soul a star. Just before labor began, the last star rays sank into my belly. My husband would talk to me and not go, though I said for him to return to the battlefield.” (Kingston 17)

“My American life has been such a disappointment.” (Kingston 21)

“There is a Chinese word for the female I—which is “slave.” Break the women with their own tongues! I refused to cook. When I had to wash dishes, I would crack one or two. “Bad girl,” my mother yelled, and sometimes that made me gloat rather than cry. Isn’t a bad girl almost a boy?” (Kingston 22)



"Maxine Hong Kingston" by Keith Jenkins is licensed under [CC BY-NC-ND 2.0](#).

Work Cited

Chow, Karen. "Maxine Hong Kingston: Overview." *Reference Guide to American Literature*, edited by Jim Kamp, 3rd ed., St. James Press, 1994. *Gale Literature Resource Center*, link.gale.com/apps/doc/H1420004612/LitRC?u=m1n_c_fitcol&sid=bookmark-LitRC&xid=ae416538. Accessed 11 Dec. 2022.

He, Qiong. "Reconstructing the Past: Reproduction of Trauma in Maxine Hong Kingston's *The Woman Warrior*." *Theory and Practice in Language Studies*, vol. 9, no. 2, 2019, pp. 131-6.

Kingston, Maxine Hong. *The Woman Warrior : Memoirs of a Girlhood among Ghosts*. Vintage Books, 1989.

Nishime, LeiLani. "Engendering genre: gender and nationalism in 'China Men' and 'The Woman Warrior'." *MELUS*, vol. 20, no. 1, spring 1995, pp. 67+. *Gale Literature Resource Center*, link.gale.com/apps/doc/A17634873/LitRC?u=m1n_c_fitcol&sid=bookmark-LitRC&xid=7c5eb2d1. Accessed 11 Dec. 2022.

Essay 2

The Woman Warrior: Memoirs of a Girlhood Among Ghosts

Nicki Lovenbury

The Woman Warrior: Memoirs of a Girlhood Among Ghosts by Chinese-American author Maxine Hong-Kingston, is an autobiography told by a collection of Chinese folktales. These folktales, or short stories include *No Name Woman*, *White Tigers*, *Shaman*, *At the Western Palace*, and *A song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe*. Throughout each story there is a common idea presented that women are essentially useless in Chinese culture, or as Kingston puts it in *White Tigers*, “It is more profitable to raise geese than daughters” (Kingston 43). In *The Woman Warrior*, Kingston disputes how these negative ideas about women affect her view of

herself and the way she navigates life. She talks mostly about the things she has experienced growing up in her Chinese-American family and the things she was raised to believe. Kingston shares her struggle with self-identity through imaginative storytelling. I chose this selection for the anthology because Maxine Hong-Kingston is a unique writer who shares her experiences genuinely and vulnerably. Overall, Kingston seeks to create a name and identity for herself as a Chinese-American woman that she can share with the world through her writing.

No Name Woman tells the story of Kingston's aunt who kills herself and her newborn. After her husband leaves for several years, the aunt sleeps with a man and becomes pregnant. The village soon finds out and breaks into her house, destroying everything. The aunt decides to jump into a well, killing herself and the illegitimate child. Kingston's mother tells her the story as a sort of warning, causing Kingston to fear she may end up like her aunt. The family goes on to pretend her aunt never even existed, not even speaking her name- hence the name of the story; *No Name Woman*. The next section, *White Tigers*, draws from a traditional Chinese myth that tells the story of Fa Mu Lan. Fa Mu Lan is a girl who trains for years to become a great warrior, disguises herself as a man, raises an army and wins wars against her enemies and even has a baby along the way. Kingston tells the story as if she is the woman in the story, comparing the journey to her own life in America. This story helps Kingston discover that she has the ability to be as powerful as Fa Mu Lan by using her words to break down traditional stereotypes and gender roles. *Shaman* is a story about Kingston's mother, Brave Orchid, who becomes a doctor after the passing of her two children in China. While attending school, Brave Orchid fights and scares away a ghost and when she returns to her village, she is treated as a shaman as a result of this and her healing abilities as a doctor. Towards the end, Kingston explains how her mother thinks work is hard in America and that time passes too quickly. Brave Orchid tells Kingston they no longer own any land in China and will never return, and even asks her to come move back in. Kingston expresses that she is too bothered by ghosts when she is home, and Brave Orchid seems to understand. In the next story *At the Western Palace* Brave Orchid's sister, Moon Orchid, comes to visit her and her family in America. Brave Orchid looks down on Moon Orchid because she struggles to perform easy tasks like laundry and dishes, but Brave Orchid wants to help her sister get back on track. Moon Orchid's husband had already moved to America many years ago and now has a new wife and children. Brave Orchid encourages her sister to go and talk to her husband and reclaim her life. This does not end well for Moon Orchid, as her husband says he wants nothing to do with her. Moon Orchid starts to become delusional and fear Mexican ghosts are coming for her. Ultimately, Brave Orchid takes her sister to a mental asylum where she dies. In the last story, *A song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe*, Kingston starts by explaining how she has always had a hard time communicating. She talks about a quiet Chinese girl in her class who she really did not like. Kingston teases the girl at one point, trying to get her to talk by calling her names, pulling her hair and making the girl cry. She feels like karma punishes her when she mysteriously becomes sick and bed ridden for over a year. She also talks about other individuals who she views as crazy like Crazy Mary and Pee-A-Nah. Kingston herself feels like the crazy person in her family and she creates, in her mind, a list of confessions she would like to tell her mother. In the end, she talks about Ts'ai Yen, who was captured by barbarians and brought back the popular Chinese hymn "A Song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe."

"It is more profitable to raise geese than daughters" (Kingston 43).

For this anthology, I am going to focus on primarily *No Name Woman* and *A song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe*. It is clear that the most prevalent topic in each of Kingston's folktales is her struggle with her identity as a woman in her culture. Brave Orchid is a great cause of these inner battles that Kingston deals with and discusses throughout the book. In *No Name Woman*, Kingston shares her fears of who she might become. These fears are of course the result of the story her mother told her about her aunt. At one point Brave Orchid even says "what happened to her could happen to you. Don't humiliate us" (Kingston 13). Kingston's aunt fell into the connotation that women are useless in Chinese culture. Her family pretended that she never even existed because of her mistakes essentially saying that she is useless and forgettable. Kingston also brought up a point in *No Name Woman* saying that the child her aunt gave birth to was most likely a girl, so it made her aunt more inclined to kill herself and the child because she knew there was no hope for the child's future. In *Mother Daughter Writing and the Politics of Race and Sex in Maxine Hong Kingston's 'The Woman Warrior'*, an essay by Wendy Ho, she explains "the Chinese mother and family attempt to instill in the young daughter (even in America) the virtues and habits that are considered ideally feminine in traditional Chinese culture" (Ho). Kingston's mother instills the fears of becoming a disgrace like her aunt in her mind, putting her in a box and essentially saying that because she is also a woman she could be destined for the same fate. Although Kingston was raised in said traditional Chinese-American family, she never felt like she would grow up to be the person her family expected her to be. In *A song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe*, Kingston says, "I want to be a lumberjack and a newspaper reporter" (Kingston 196). In the essay *Empowerment through Mythological Imaginings in Woman Warrior* by Sue Ann Johnston, Johnston speaks on this quote saying, "With her slight physique

and her bookish propensities, Kingston is clearly not telling a literal "truth" in this "truthful" confrontation with her mother, but an imaginative one. What Kingston is really saying is that she will not be hemmed in by convention" (Johnston). Kingston repeatedly makes it clear that her gender is not something that defines her or her future. Even considering the fact that Kingston is being raised in America where she doesn't have to abide by Chinese rules for women as strictly, her family still upholds their traditional views and expects Kingston to follow. In conclusion, Kingston sharing her experiences and becoming a successful author is her way of proving that the social and cultural proposition that women are not even on the same level as geese, is untrue. Kingston does not let society, her family or her culture restrict her and define her role as an individual.

Excerpt from *Woman Warrior*

I watched our parents buy a sofa, then a rug, curtains, chairs to replace the orange and apple crates one by one, now to be used for storage. Good. At the beginning of the second Communist ve-year plan, our parents bought a car. But you could see the relatives and the villagers getting more worried about what to do with the girls. We had three girl second cousins, no boys; their great-grandfather and our grandfather were brothers. The great-grandfather was the old man who lived with them, as the river-pirate great-uncle was the old man who lived with us. When my sisters and I ate at their house, there we would be—six girls eating. The old man opened his eyes wide at us and turned in a circle, surrounded. His neck tendons stretched out. "Maggots!" he shouted. "Maggots! Where are my grandsons? I want grandsons! Give me grandsons! Maggots!" He pointed at each one of us, "Maggot! Maggot! Maggot! Maggot! Maggot!" Then he dived into his food, eating fast and getting seconds. "Eat, maggots," he said. "Look at the maggots chew."

"He does that at every meal," the girls told us in English.

"Yeah," we said. "Our old man hates us too. What assholes."

"Third Grand-Uncle nally did get a boy, though, his only great-grandson. The boy's parents and the old man bought him toys, bought him everything—new diapers, new plastic pants—not homemade diapers, not bread bags. They gave him a full-month party inviting all the emigrant villagers; they deliberately hadn't given the girls parties, so that no one would notice another girl. Their brother got toy trucks that were big enough to climb inside. When he grew older, he got a bicycle and let the girls play with his old tricycle and wagon. My mother bought his sisters a typewriter. "They can be clerk-typists," their father kept saying, but he would not buy them a typewriter.

"What an asshole," I said, muttering the way my father muttered "Dog vomit" when the customers nagged him about missing socks.

Maybe my mother was afraid that I'd say things like that out loud and so had cut my tongue. Now again plans were urgently afoot to improve my voice. The wealthiest villager wife came to the laundry one day to have a listen. "You better do something with this one," she told my mother. "She has an ugly voice. She quacks like a pressed duck." Then she looked at me unnecessarily hard; Chinese do not have to address children directly. "You have what we call a pressed-duck voice," she said. This woman was the giver of American names, a powerful namer, though it was American names; my parents gave the Chinese names. And she was right: if you squeezed the duck hung up to dry in the east window, the sound that was my voice would come out of it. She was a woman of such power that all we immigrants and descendants of immigrants were obliged to her family forever for bringing us here and for finding us jobs, and she had named my voice. (Kingston 185-6)



"[Maxine Hong-Kingston](#)" by Judy Dater is licensed under [CC BY-NC 2.0](#).

Work Cited

Ho, Wendy. "Mother Daughter Writing and the Politics of Race and Sex in Maxine Hong Kingston's 'The Woman Warrior,'" *Contemporary Literary Criticism*, edited by Jeffrey W. Hunter and Polly Vedder, vol. 121, Gale, 2000.

Johnston, Sue Anne. "Empowerment through Mythological Imaginings in *Woman Warrior*." *Contemporary Literary Criticism*, edited by Jeffrey W. Hunter and Polly Vedder, vol. 121, Gale, 2000.

Kingston, Maxine Hong. *The Woman Warrior : Memoirs of a Girlhood among Ghosts*. Vintage Books, 1989.

7: [Maxine Hong Kingston \(1940-\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

8: Gloria Anzaldúa (1942-2004)

Gloria Anzaldúa

Derek Schumaker

Essay

Gloria Anzaldúa is an Ethnic American Literature author that is often studied. She is a female author who comes from a Latina background, and specifically from Chicana descent. Gloria Anzaldúa was a culturally diverse person with ties to many different Latina practices and different language dialects. For example, “Chicanas who grew up speaking Chicano Spanish have internalized the belief that we speak poor Spanish. It is illegitimate, a bastard language. And because we internalize how our language has been used against us by the dominant culture, we use our language differences against each other.” (Anzaldúa 58). Oftentimes in her literary works, Gloria Anzaldúa would focus on the struggle to find her own self-identity. She would write about how she would talk one way and act another depending on the company surrounding her because she did not know what to say and how to present herself. For example, Mariana Ortega discusses why people would conform to society when they could just act like themselves. Ortega says, “In a powerful critique against the philosophical tendency to answer the famous/infamous question of personal identity, of finding the criteria to explain selfhood over time, by way of an appeal to thought experiments, Brison asks, Why resort to “fusion, fission, freezing dissolution, reconstitution and/or teletransportation” (Brison, 13) when we can use our own experience to understand who we are?” (Ortega 239). She grew up in a time period where people were fighting for their rights and wanting to be accepted. It is pretty understandable for a person of Latina descent to be confused as to who she really is at that time in United States history, especially because the white male audience dominated the culture in the United States and wanted to micromanage everything that was going on in society.

“A counterstance locks one into a duel of oppressor and oppressed; locked in mortal combat, like the cop and the criminal, both are reduced to a common denominator of violence.”

One of the main themes that seems to stand out in many of Gloria Anzaldúa’s works is the struggle to find her own self-identity and or pride in herself. One of the reasons why she writes so passionately about her struggle is because she grew up in a time period in the United States where it was looked down upon to speak foreign languages, especially those that descend from Latin America.. In other words, Gloria Anzaldúa offers first hand accounts of the struggle she goes through each and every day along with her passionate personality and fiery sense of being through her resistance to conformity. As she grew up, Anzaldúa refused to conform with society and let white people walk all over her. Rather, she would write how she wanted to, spoke how she wanted, and behave on her own terms to help create her own Chicana American self. Anzaldúa was a mentor and teacher to people growing up in the United States that it is okay to be different and be a symbol of hope. In other words, Anzaldúa was a feminist who would try to integrate different cultures together. In a critique of Anzaldúa, the author brought up this topic about her. For example, “What I did not know but learned from Chicana feminists like Anzaldúa was that the Americas produced indigenous discourses of friendship that recognized and attempted to redress the asymmetry of intercultural relations, by producing, rather than initially requiring, equality.” (Schweitzer pg. 287).

Another personal struggle that Gloria Anzaldúa faced growing up was being a woman in general, and being a lesbian. She would constantly get put down by the male discourse of society. For example, ““You’re nothing but a woman” means you are defective. Its opposite is to be un macho.”” (Anzaldúa 83). Anzaldúa feels as though she does not belong to any specific culture because of who she is as a person. Anzaldúa says, “As a mestiza I have no country, my homeland cast me out; yet all countries are mine because I am every woman’s sister or potential lover. (As a lesbian I have no race,. my own people disclaim me; but I am all races because there is the queer of me in all races.)” (Anzaldúa 80). Even after all of the discrimination against her and the constant negativity surrounding her life choices, Anzaldúa made the best of her situations and persevered to become a well-known feminist author in the United States.

Excerpt

“ Within us and within la cultura chicana, commonly held beliefs of the white culture attack commonly held beliefs of the culture, and both attack commonly held beliefs of the Mexican culture. Subconsciously, we see an attack on ourselves and our beliefs as a threat and we attempt to block with a counterstance.

But it is not enough to stand on the opposite river bank, shouting questions, challenging patriarchal, white conventions. A counterstance locks one into a duel of oppressor and oppressed; locked in mortal combat, like the cop and the criminal, both are reduced to a common denominator of violence. The counterstance refutes the dominant culture's views and beliefs and, for this, it is proudly defiant. All reanion is limited! by, and dependent on, what it is reacting against. Because the counterstance stems from a problem with authority- outer as well as inner-it's a step towards liberation from cultural domination. But it is not a way of life. At some point, on our way to a new consciousness, we will have to leave the opposite bank, the split between the two mortal combatants somehow healed so that we are on both shores at once and, at once, see through serpent and eagle eyes. Or perhaps we will decide to disengage from the dominant culture, write it off altogether as a lost cause, and cross the border into a wholly new and separate territory. Or we might go another route. The possibilities are numerous once we decide to act and not react."



"Gloria Anzaldúa" by K. Kendall is licensed under [CC BY 2.0](#).

Works Cited

Anzaldúa, Gloria. "Borderlands/La Frontera." Aunt Lute Books Company, 1987.

Ortega, Mariana. "Wounds of Self: Experience, Word, Image, and Identity." *The Journal of Speculative Philosophy*, vol. 22, no. 4, 2008, pp. 235-47.

Schweitzer, Ivy. "For Gloria Anzaldúa: Collecting America, Performing Friendship." *PMLA*, vol. 121, no. 1, 2006, pp. 285-91.

8: [Gloria Anzaldúa \(1942-2004\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

9: August Wilson (1945-2005)

Generational Consequences

Rebecca Joseph

August Wilson is known as the “Theater Poet of Black America”. The Playwright explores themes like the “search for identity, racial exploitation and injustice, empowerment through the blues, and spiritual regeneration” (Little 290). He focuses on the “‘internal examination’ of African American life rather than the ‘pushing forward’ of overt political propaganda”(Little 291). According to critic Daniel Scott III, “Wilson believes that artistic imagination overshadows any need for historical accuracy, especially as he tries to deconstruct entrenched misconceptions about African Americans among his wider audiences and, by so doing, alter customary patterns of behavior and thought. He believes his mission is not so much to challenge the past but to bring it once again into focus, ‘to exemplify for today’s audiences how African Americans emerged triumphant’” (Scott).

The play, *Fences*, is set in 1950s Pittsburg and follows Troy Maxson who once had a promising future in baseball but circumstances as a youth led him down a path that landed him in jail. Being an ex-convict out of the system, he became a garbage collector, settled down with Rose, and started a family. It examines how external racism affects interpersonal relationships, the friction causing the oppression to be sent down the family line, and eventually manifesting into generational curses we inevitably trap ourselves in.

We start off on a Friday evening, payday; Troy and Bono congregate at Troy’s house for their ritualistic drink and talk. We learn Troy has asked their boss why the black employees only move the garbage and aren’t allowed to drive the trucks. Bono suspects Troy of being unfaithful to Rose. Their son, Cory, has a chance to be recruited by a college football team. The news is bitter for Troy because he once played for the Negro Leagues and had a future in baseball but became too old to play for the Major Leagues by the time it was formed. Rose reminds him to finish putting the fence up. As he and Cory work on the fence together, Cory tells him he has left his job at the grocery store, A&P, for the football season. Troy refuses to allow him to quit and demands he instead quit the team and get his job back. Cory wonders why his father doesn’t like him and he unexpectedly informs him there was no rule that said he was obligated to. Like his father before him, he simply had a responsibility to care for him.

By the end of the act, it is next Friday. Troy has been promoted, assigned the first colored garbage truck driver in the city. He and Bono talk about their experience leaving the south, their fathers, and moving north. The day he left, at fourteen, was the same day his father had knocked him out when he caught him with a girl. He became homeless and started thieving which landed him in prison for fifteen years where he learned to play baseball. Cory comes home and confronts his father after finding out he told the coach not to let him play, causing him to lose his one chance to be recruited. Troy has no remorse, telling him he shouldn’t waste his time on sports, things that’ll fill his head with trash and instead learn a trade; something they can’t take away from him. He warns him his insubordination is “strike one.”

Troy must bail his brother, Gabriel, out of jail. As Troy and Bono work on the fence he admits to his affair with Alberta. Bono sees that Rose wants to build the fence to keep what she loves close to her. When Troy tells Rose about the hearing for Gabriel to be recommitted he admits to his affair. Rose gives Troy a piece of her mind and we learn how unsatisfied with the state of his life he is and he and Cory begin to fight. When Troy wins he tells him that is “strike two.”

Six months later, Alberta dies in childbirth and Troy brings home a baby girl. Rose tells him because he was not there Gabriel was signed away. Troy has completed the fence and tells Cory he must provide for himself. Cory brings up his shortcoming with Rose, and how the house and property he was attempting to remove him from was paid for by Gabriel’s government checks. This sparks another attack and he kicks him out.

Eight years later, Cory has joined the marines and everyone has come together for Troy’s funeral. Cory refuses to attend and Rose tells him that won’t make him a man. In the end he and his younger sister, Raynell, bond.

In *The Fire Next Time*, Baldwin talks about how his grandfather had been long defeated even before his death. His father wanted him to follow in his footsteps because the future he wanted seemed unattainable to him. The system was built to predetermine their futures in a way that held most in the same circumstances and there were only so many opportunities that offered a way out and a better future. “Every Negro boy-in my situation during those years, at least-who reaches this point realizes, at once, profoundly, because he wants to live, that he stands in great peril and must find, with speed, a “thing”, a gimmick, to lift him out, to start him on his way...I could not become a prizefighter- many of us tried but very few succeeded. I could not sing. I could not dance. I had been well conditioned by the world in which I grew up, so I did not yet dare take the idea of becoming a writer seriously” (Baldwin

35). What seems to happen with men like Troy and Baldwin's father is they were kicked so many times by society they came to believe that black men had no real chance to advance. They teach it to their children because they want them so badly not to be disappointed. In most cases they had "a fear that the child, in challenging the white world's assumptions, was putting himself in the path of destruction" (Baldwin 38). They play it safe, which is why he encourages Cory to find something that can't be taken from him like a trade. At one point Troy says, "The white man ain't gonna let you get nowhere with that football noway. You go on and get your book-learning so you can work yourself up in that A&P or learn how to fix cars or build houses or something, get you a trade. That way you have something ain't nobody can take away from you. You go on and learn how to put your hands to some good use. Besides hauling people's garbage" (Wilson). He sees dreams as trash, a call to his failed dreams and current occupation, yet in this he still manages to create victories for himself and his people. Unfortunately damaged men are trying to be fathers when their fathers weren't good fathers to them. There is also a generation of fathers who resent being fathers and don't actually like or want their children, like Troy and his father. New generations are born and ready to challenge society, the old generation can not see the vision and end up creating a generation of kids that hate their parents for tearing them down the way society does. It could also be bitter seeing society make way for new generations when you were cast out during your time. Black boys in particular only have so many chances to make a future happen for them and Cory got that. For Troy, there is a level of envy seeing his son have a possible future in something that was a missed opportunity for him. That is why he sabotages his chances of being recruited to a college football team. In a way the envy he has towards Cory is similar to the jealousy his father had when he caught him with the girl. When society has so vehemently led you to believe you will aspire to nothing more than what they define you, it is difficult to see things any other way. When there is an opportunity to change the course of the future, it should be taken.

Opportunities are scarce because of race, black people are limited in society, held down and oppressed by white people, limited job opportunities and bias in the workplace. As society holds them down they begin to oppress and limit themselves. They see the same happen to those around and it creates a sort of self-resentment for the hand dealt to them in life. It's not difficult to see how those scars wouldn't be passed down. However society advances and as more black people are given chances their predecessors weren't, those monsters can rear their heads. A cycle of self-sabotage is created, in the form of ruining your child's future or betraying your spouse like Troy and so many others have. In a sense, Troy is conspicuous by his presence as *Fences* stages the stresses and tensions whereby sons attempt to both escape and emulate fathers. Troy recalls his father's sense of responsibility and recalcitrance: "My daddy ain't had them walking blues! What you talking about? He stayed right there with his family. But he was just as evil as he could be. ... He wasn't good for nobody" (Brewer).

It is a fitting message that at the end the children sit together symbolizing new generations working to create a hopefully better future by breaking those barriers for the next generation. Create a cycle that will build each other up rather than tear each other down. When you have the fortune then create that community. There is power in numbers and when you come together to make a change happen, people listen. *Fences* could be seen as that thing holding you trapped in or protection for that community or family. This fits well with our discussions on race affecting class and that deciding our future and position in life, opportunities for minorities presenting themselves in limited ways in society, as well as how family dynamics are strengthened or broken by the very real oppression externally we allow ourselves to be consumed in internally and how it can poison generations.



"August Wilson" by The Huntington is licensed under [CC BY 2.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/).

Work Cited

Baldwin, James. *Fire next Time*. Knopf Doubleday Publishing Group, 1992.

Brewer, Gaylord. "Holy and Unholy Ghosts: The Legacy of the Father in the Plays of August Wilson." *Drama Criticism*, edited by Thomas J. Schoenberg and Lawrence J. Trudeau, vol. 31, Gale, 2008.

Little, Jonathan. "August Wilson." *Dictionary of Literary Biography*, edited by Christopher J. Wheatley, The Gale Group, 2000, 289-302

Scott, Daniel M. III. "The Dramatic Vision of August Wilson." *MELUS*, vol. 24, no. 3, fall 1999, p. 163.

Wilson, August. *Fences: August Wilson*. Samuel French, 2010.

9: [August Wilson \(1945-2005\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

10: Leslie Marmon Silko (1948-)

Essay 1

Leslie Marmon Silko

Kayla Forbes

Leslie Marmon Silko is a Laguna Pueblo Indian woman known for her novels and poems. Self-identity is the main theme in her works. Silko is known to write about her Laguna Pueblo Indian culture and rituals. Silko is most known for her novels, *Ceremony* and *Yellow Women*. The one novel that stood out which is not as well known is *The Man to Send Rainclouds*. *The Man to Send Rainclouds* is about the relationship between Laguna Pueblo customs and Christianity. Self-identity and resistance are the two main themes of the short story. Silko's family background is very important to her. Her family taught her about her identity and now it is an important theme in all of her stories.

Growing up, self-identity has always been important to Silko. While Silko was growing up her family was passionate for her to know and embrace her Indian culture. The people who helped her most understand and embrace Laguna Pueblo Indian Culture were her grandmother and grandfather and many more. The most helpful was “ ‘Grandma Amoooh,’ because of her Presbyterian conviction acquired at Carlisle Indian School, she told her family stories and community history, she refrained from telling creation mythology – the wealth of hummah-hah stories that Silko heard from Aunts Susie and Alice” (Knopf). She grew up hearing the traditional stories of Laguna people. According to scholars William Clements and Kenneth Roemer, “The most important lessons they taught Silko reflected the emphasis on the forces of continuity and adaptability in Laguna traditional culture - forces that their position in Laguna society and that of their Marmon ancestors had demonstrated, and which appear in Silko's poetry and fiction” (Clements 175). All of Silko pieces relate and consist of Laguna Tradition. She is a storyteller in all her works. All Silko pieces are also about her identity and her Laguna ancestry. She does not hide how she grew up and the culture she grew up in. Silko's short stories and poems are about her background and the way she was raised which is very important to her.

“You know I can't do that, Leon. There should have been the Last Rites and a funeral Mass at the very least”.

Silko's first publication happened while in college at the University of New Mexico. She published the short story, *The Man to Send Rainclouds*. *The Man to Send Rainclouds* is a true story that happened in Laguna about the tensions between Laguna Pueblo customs and the Catholic Church. In *The Man to Send Rainclouds*, a man named Teofilo passes away and his family members Leon and Ken find his body. Leon and Ken bring Teofilo's body back to their home to give him a traditional burial. The family was missing one important step for Teofilo's burial. They were missing water from a priest, and the only way of receiving water was by asking the priest of the Catholic Church to put water on the burial. Father Paul did not want to give holy water to Teofilo because they did not do the burial in the correct Christian way. Father Paul ends up putting the water on the burial while questioning the rituals. Silko's story shows resistance. Resistance is shown when the family does not do it the Catholic way. They stick with their rituals. They stick to their values and beliefs. Their identity of being a Laguna Pueblo Indian is very important to follow the traditions when someone passes.

During the time Silko wrote these short stories tensions were high between Native American customs and Christian customs. She wants to resolve the tensions between them. “In ‘The Man to Send Rain Clouds’ the family decides to take a limited dispensation from Christianity—as much as will suit the demands of the community and align with the wishes of the departed individual ” (Devi and Singh). Silko wants her readers to destroy stereotypes of the Natives. I was raised as a Christian and learned so much about the religion. Reading *The Man to Send Rainclouds* helped me understand another custom. It was interesting reading how the Catholic Church and the Laguna Pueblo customs bury a body differently. One of Silko's goals in writing her stories is to have other people learn more about her culture. I believe she achieves this goal because now I can understand more about her and the way she grew up.



"Reading from her new memoir" by Uche Ogbuji is licensed under [CC BY-SA 2.0](#).

Excerpt

"Traditional ways have also continued, however, and despite her ancestors' negative impact on some aspects of Laguna tradition, Silko was made well aware of the Indian side of her heritage during her childhood. In addition to Grandma A'mooh, an important source of Laguna cultural knowledge for Silko was Susie Reyes Marmon, the wife of her grandfather's brother. Having attended both Carlisle Indian School and Dickinson College, Aunt Susie taught school at Laguna in the 1920s, while maintaining her commitment to the community's oral tradition. She handed that commitment on to Silko" (Clements 175).

Work Cited

Clements, William and Kenneth Roemer. "Leslie (Marmom) Silko." *Native American Writers of the United States*, Dictionary of Literary Biography, vol. 175, Gale, 1997.

Devi, Babita and Divyajyoti Singh. "Silko's Narrative Negotiation of the Rain Man's Rites of the Passage." *The Explicator*, vol. 79, no. 4, 2021, pp. 160-5.

Knopf, Kerstin. "Leslie Marmon Silko (1948-). *Handbook of the American Short Story*, edited by Erik Redling and Oliver Scheiding, De Gruyter, 2022, pp. 533-54.

Essay 2

Leslie Marmon Silko

Jorjia Tsilibocos

I chose Silko because she represents female empowerment and tried her best for people who don't feel like they belong, that they do. Everyone needs a home.

Silko had a very strong yet complicated relationship with her heritage but has always chosen to focus on her Native American ancestors/non-Indian relatives. The themes of her writing center the struggle of those with mixed blood to find acceptance/understanding of her work. Silko said "The core of my writing is the attempt to identify what it is to be a half breed or a mixed blood person; what is it to grow up neither white nor fully traditional Indian" (Clements 256). She is noting here how she understands first hand to not feel like she identifies fully with one culture versus another. This is where her constant theme of self identity and resistance come out. She understands the pain and hurt that comes with feeling like you don't belong. Her writing is also noted to come from direct first hand experiences with her main influence being her great grandmother named Maria.

As I started to learn about her literature, I started to grasp concepts between different yellow woman stories and the deep origin of how tradition works within the Laguna Pueblo. Tradition is important because it gives you a sense of understanding and true love. It gives you a way to connect with your ancestors. It makes you feel as though you belong, and you can pass on these traditions to your children. Tradition is created, so the ancestors can live on through their living relatives. This concept is vital in Silko's writing. Silko was just emphasizing the importance of not only tradition, but how you felt so deeply connected. One of her most famous literature pieces was entitled "Yellow woman". It was said "Yellow Woman being abducted by a male spiritual being and sacrificing herself for the good of her people, or returning to the community. The analysis brings to the fore the beauty and richness of the story that is steeped in cultural lore, the land and its stories" (Knopf 28).

All in all, there have been many themes regarding Silko and wanting everyone to read her novels to take home the most important thing. Everybody is special and uniquely built. No one is supposed to be exactly the same, because that would be boring. Silkos multiple yellow woman stories overall mean that all of these women felt that they did not belong because they didn't identify with traditions. Either they were lured or forced with the mysterious man. Silko messages are still prevalent to this day. That is why I really liked learning about Silko and her writing style because I think everyone can relate to it and understand it.

Work Cited

Clements, William and Kenneth Roemer. "Leslie (Marmom) Silko." *Native American Writers of the United States*, Dictionary of Literary Biography, vol. 175, Gale, 1997.

Knopf, Kerstin. "Leslie Marmon Silko (1948-). *Handbook of the American Short Story*, edited by Erik Redling and Oliver Scheiding, De Gruyter, 2022, pp. 533-54.

10: [Leslie Marmon Silko \(1948-\)](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

11: Afterword

Jennie Snow, Ph.D.

Assistant Professor of English Studies

The students of “Ethnic American Literature” – Chris, Kayla, Shianne, Tre, Rebecca, Sam K., Alice, Nicki, Kerns, Cyan, Juan, Justin, Isaiah, Derek, Pedro, Jorjia, Danielle, and Ketia – are the first students I met when I started at Fitchburg State University in Fall 2022. I had prepared what I thought would be an eclectic syllabus to build a conversation about the moniker “ethnic American literature” and what’s really caught up in it. We wasted no time and kicked off our first meeting by reading out loud from James Baldwin’s “My Dungeon Shook,” the first part of *The Fire Next Time*. One student immediately seized on the message of love that rang through Baldwin’s letter about the American traps of race and racism — this student expressed the challenge of holding the tension in his text, why would Baldwin emphasize *this* message? In many ways this became our investigation for the next two weeks, which then set the framework for the rest of our discussions that semester as we explored indigenous, Latinx, Asian American and African American literary expressions.

In the syllabus I offered this description of the course:

This course examines the complex, intertwined histories of race and ethnicity in the U.S. through literature by focusing on two key inflection points: 1965 and 1865. We begin with the surge of “ethnic” American literature in the 1960s when Black, Asian, U.S. Latinx, and Indigenous groups fought for more recognition of their traditions and innovative contributions to American culture as part of the broader struggle for Civil Rights. This moment is key to understanding how we recognize ethnic American writing as such. However, as James Baldwin reminds, the struggles of the mid-twentieth century were nothing new; this fight was a reverberation of centuries-old struggles for rights, recognition, freedom, and in the case of Native Americans, sovereignty. Thus, we must look back to history to see how these groups have always spoken up and spoken truth to power. To this end, the second part of our course will critically frame the first by revisiting a previous era, circa 1865, through both contemporary and historical voices.

Putting this all together, we investigate how multiethnic American literature is innovated and received. Rather than focalize a particular identity, community, or history, this course will foreground multiracial formations and solidarities. We are interested in particularity and nuance among different communities but will resist the temptation to isolate or essentialize a single ethnic group’s experiences. We instead question how “ethnic” American literature expands our understanding of “America” and what it means to be “American,” and we will explore key issues, fissures, and tensions across these literary traditions. Some of these topics include: race and ethnicity, white supremacy, identity, gender and sexuality, class, (im)migration, memory and storytelling, homeland(s), cultural traditions, hybridity, and political activism.

While I was responsible for the initial design, it was merely a shell to provide us a space for discussion, and the students really created the course. In the first part of the semester students wrote their own “concept meditations” in which they identified a concept that related to a number of authors/texts and analyze the meaning across them. Students explored how these concepts revealed common themes and messages and how meaning shifted in different contexts, histories, and positionalities. Students then worked together to connect these concepts into a framework that we could analyze in the second part of the semester as we read Toni Morrison’s groundbreaking *Beloved* and a contemporary companion in C. Pam Zhang’s *How Much of These Hills*. We traced our main concepts – self identity and resistance – through our new readings and began discussing the power of writing and *gathering* writing in an anthology. The anthology as a genre itself embodies our themes. The act of collecting is an assertion of identity that can also be leveraged as resistance to dominant culture, mainstream stories, or forgetful histories.

As best we could, this text was made to reflect our semester of collaboration and conversation. When we analyzed Harriet Jacobs’ *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl*, we wrestled with the double-sided politics of L. Maria Child’s editorial power. How differently do we encounter Jacobs’ voice than we do Sethe’s or Morrison’s? How might Child’s stewardship play out within our own context of the university, with student and teacher, with our own collective text? In addition to student-written entries, students served as the editors with the responsibility of introducing the anthology as a whole. We often returned to the significance of the *Aiiieeee!* *Anthology of Asian-American Writers* and how this challenged the perceptions of what counts as literature, who counts as a writer, and how to challenge the inertia of the publishing industry. Likewise, we took time to discuss the meaning of creating an open educational resource for others and how creative commons licenses would permit individual writers to share their work with the

public while claiming their rights as authors. All said and done, the student-writers showcased in this collection opted for some degree of open-access with the understanding that their contributions – their knowledge – could build forward.

We hope this anthology, one interpretation of ethnic American literature, can be a starting point for discussion, an inspiration for discovery, and a provocation for collaboration. To the students of ENGL 2650: it was an absolute pleasure to learn with you, and from you, during our course together.



11: [Afterword](#) is shared under a [CC BY-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

Feedback

Feedback Form

Please send us feedback using [this google form](#).



403. That's an error.

We're sorry, but you do not have access to this page.
That's all we know.

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [A Compact Anthology of Multiethnic American Literature: Student Edition](#)

Webpages: 26

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-SA 4.0](#): 88.5% (23 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 11.5% (3 pages)

By Page

- [A Compact Anthology of Multiethnic American Literature: Student Edition](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Acknowledgements](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Authors and Contributors](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9: August Wilson \(1945-2005\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [1: FSU Land and Labor Acknowledgment](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [8: Gloria Anzaldúa \(1942-2004\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2: How to Use this Source and Licensing Information](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [3: Introduction- Self-Identity and Resistance](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [4: Jesús Colón \(1901-1974\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [6: Toni Morrison \(1931-2019\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [10: Leslie Marmon Silko \(1948-\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [5: Lorraine Hansberry \(1930-1965\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [7: Maxine Hong Kingston \(1940-\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [11: Afterword](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Feedback](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [A Compact Anthology of Multiethnic American Literature: Student Edition](#)

Webpages: 26

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-SA 4.0](#): 88.5% (23 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 11.5% (3 pages)

By Page

- [A Compact Anthology of Multiethnic American Literature: Student Edition](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Acknowledgements](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Authors and Contributors](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9: August Wilson \(1945-2005\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [1: FSU Land and Labor Acknowledgment](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [8: Gloria Anzaldúa \(1942-2004\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2: How to Use this Source and Licensing Information](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [3: Introduction- Self-Identity and Resistance](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [4: Jesús Colón \(1901-1974\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [6: Toni Morrison \(1931-2019\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [10: Leslie Marmon Silko \(1948-\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [5: Lorraine Hansberry \(1930-1965\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [7: Maxine Hong Kingston \(1940-\)](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [11: Afterword](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Feedback](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)